

Understanding Your Hearing Loss

Category: Understand Your Hearing

Best for: Newly diagnosed adults, adults considering hearing aids, family members

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What does it mean to have hearing loss?

Hearing loss means that your ears and hearing system are not picking up sound as clearly or easily as they once did. For some people, sounds may seem softer. For others, speech may sound unclear, muffled, or distorted, even when the speaker is loud enough. This is why many adults with hearing loss say, “I can hear people talking, but I cannot always understand what they are saying.”

Hearing loss is common in adults. It can happen gradually over time, suddenly, or as a result of noise exposure, aging, illness, injury, medications, genetics, or other medical conditions. About 15% of adults in the United States report some trouble hearing, and hearing loss becomes more common with age (National Institute on Deafness and Other Communication Disorders [NIDCD], 2023).

Hearing loss can affect more than your ability to hear sounds. It can affect conversations, relationships, work, safety, energy level, confidence, and participation in daily life. The good news is that hearing loss can often be managed with the right combination of education, communication strategies, hearing technology, medical care when needed, and support from family and friends.

Why do I hear some sounds but miss words?

Speech is made of many different sounds. Some speech sounds are low-pitched and easier to hear, such as vowel sounds. Other speech sounds are high-pitched and softer, such as /s/, /f/, /th/, /sh/, /t/, and /k/. These high-frequency sounds carry a lot of speech clarity.

Many adults have more difficulty hearing high-frequency sounds. When this happens, speech may seem loud enough but not clear enough. For example, you may hear someone talking, but you may miss the difference between words like “cat,” “cap,” “cast,” or “cash.”

This can be especially difficult in background noise. Restaurants, family gatherings, cars, waiting rooms, and group conversations can make listening harder because your brain has to separate speech from competing sounds. Hearing loss can make this separation more difficult, even when you are paying close attention.

The three main types of hearing loss

There are three main types of hearing loss: conductive, sensorineural, and mixed (American Speech-Language-Hearing Association [ASHA], n.d.).

Conductive hearing loss

Conductive hearing loss happens when sound has trouble traveling through the outer ear or middle ear. This may happen because of earwax, fluid behind the eardrum, an ear infection, a hole in the eardrum, or problems with the tiny bones of the middle ear.

Some conductive hearing losses are temporary or medically treatable. Others may need long-term management. If your audiologist suspects a medical cause, they may recommend that you see a physician or an ear, nose, and throat doctor.

Sensorineural hearing loss

Sensorineural hearing loss happens when there is damage or change in the inner ear, also called the cochlea, or in the hearing nerve pathways. This is one of the most common types of adult hearing loss. It may be related to aging, noise exposure, genetics, certain medications, or medical conditions.

Sensorineural hearing loss is often permanent. It usually cannot be corrected with medication or surgery, but it can often be managed with hearing aids, assistive listening technology, communication strategies, and regular hearing care.

Mixed hearing loss

Mixed hearing loss means there is both a conductive component and a sensorineural component. In other words, there may be a problem in the outer or middle ear and also a problem in the inner ear or hearing nerve pathway.

Management depends on what is causing each part of the hearing loss. Some people may need medical care first, followed by hearing technology or other support.

How much hearing loss do I have?

Hearing loss can range from mild to profound. Your audiologist measures hearing using a test called an audiogram. The audiogram shows the softest sounds you can hear at different pitches. It also helps show the type and degree of hearing loss.

In general:

- **Mild hearing loss** may make soft speech, distant speech, and speech in background noise harder to understand.
- **Moderate hearing loss** may make everyday conversation difficult without hearing support.
- **Severe hearing loss** may make speech very difficult to hear without hearing technology.
- **Profound hearing loss** may make it very difficult to hear speech and many environmental sounds without powerful hearing technology or implantable hearing options.

The amount of hearing loss does not tell the whole story. Two people can have similar audiograms but very different real-life experiences. Your daily communication needs, listening environments, word recognition ability, health history, and personal goals all matter.

Why does hearing loss feel so tiring?

Hearing happens in the ears, but understanding happens in the brain. When sound is unclear, your brain has to work harder to fill in missing pieces. This is called listening effort.

Listening effort can make conversations feel exhausting. You may notice that you feel more tired after meetings, family gatherings, phone calls, appointments, or noisy environments. You may also find yourself avoiding certain situations because listening takes so much energy.

This does not mean you are not trying hard enough. It means your hearing system is receiving an incomplete signal, and your brain is working extra hard to make sense of it.

How can hearing loss affect daily life?

Hearing loss can affect daily life in many ways. You may notice difficulty:

- Following conversations in restaurants or group settings
- Hearing soft voices, children's voices, or speech from another room
- Understanding speech when people wear masks or turn away
- Hearing on the phone
- Watching TV at a comfortable volume for others
- Participating in work meetings or social events
- Hearing doorbells, alarms, timers, traffic sounds, or announcements
- Feeling confident in conversations

Hearing loss can also affect relationships. Family and friends may think you are ignoring them, not paying attention, or being difficult, when the real issue is that you did not hear clearly. Over time, these misunderstandings can lead to frustration on both sides.

Unaddressed hearing loss has also been associated with social isolation, loneliness, reduced quality of life, and cognitive health concerns (Shukla et al., 2020; World Health Organization, 2026). This does not mean that hearing loss automatically causes these outcomes. It means that hearing is connected to communication, participation, and daily functioning, so it is important to manage hearing loss early and consistently.

Why early support matters

Many people wait years before getting help for hearing loss. Some adults feel embarrassed. Some feel that their hearing is "not bad enough." Others worry that hearing aids will make them look old or that they will not help.

Getting support early can make daily communication easier and may help reduce listening fatigue. Early support also gives you time to learn what helps you, practice communication strategies, and adjust to hearing technology if it is recommended.

Hearing care is not only about hearing aids. It may include:

- Understanding your hearing test results

- Learning communication strategies
- Involving family or communication partners
- Using captions or phone accessibility tools
- Trying hearing aids or assistive listening devices
- Monitoring changes in hearing over time
- Getting medical evaluation when needed
- Creating a long-term hearing care plan

What can I do now?

If you have hearing loss, you do not have to manage it alone. The first step is understanding your hearing and how it affects your real life.

You can start by asking yourself:

- Where do I have the most trouble hearing?
- Who do I have the hardest time understanding?
- What situations do I avoid because of hearing difficulty?
- What sounds or conversations matter most to me?
- What would I like to improve first?

These answers can help your audiologist recommend the best plan for you.

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